Children of a Lesser God

By Mark Medoff

NOTE: The actress in this selection should sign using ASL. The actor will interpret for the actress and should use spoken English and ASL where indicated.

A good on-line resource for ASL is http://www.aslpro.com/cgi-bin/aslpro/aslpro.cgi A completely free online dictionary of over 7200 ASL Signs

NOTE 2: This teaser opening should be both signed using ASL and spoken English by the actress. For an example of the spoken word of the deaf, check out the video at this link: http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uKKpjvPd6Xo

The following ALS speech, translated into standard English would have SARAH speaking . . . "I have nothing; no hearing, no speech, no intelligence, no language. I have only you. I don't need you. I have me alone. I don't want anything. I don't need what you want to give me. My language is just as good as yours"

SARAH: *(Signing)* Me have nothing. Me defy. Speech inept. Intelligence – tiny blockhead. English – blow away. Left one you *(point to audience)* Depend – no. Think myself enough. What do I want? Nothing. I don't need what you want to give me. I have a language that's just as good as yours!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Welcome to the world of Sarah Norman, now in her mid-twenties, who has been deaf from birth.*
ACTRESS: *In this selection, Children of a Lesser God by Mark Medoff, you'll get to witness for yourself what happens when two worlds collide.*
ACTOR: *The world of sound*
ACTRESS: *and the world of silence*
TOGETHER: *Children of a Lesser God by Mark Medoff*

JAMES: She went away from me. Or did I drive her away? I don't know. If I did it was because . . . I seem to be having trouble stringing together a complete . . . I mean, a speech therapist shouldn't be having difficulty with the language. Start

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in the beginning. In the beginning there was silence and out of that silence there could come only one thing: Speech. That's right Human speech.

TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *They meet*

JAMES: *(Sarah enters)* Well, Sarah. Could you look at me, please. Excuse me, if you don't look at me, I can't . . .

SARAH: You deaf?

JAMES: Am I deaf? No. Why? *(She stares curiously at his mouth)* I can't help detecting a certain reluctance to communicate with me. Is that because you're afraid you'll be embarrassed by the sounds you make? *(She stares at his mouth)* Are you reading my lips? I don't think you're reading my lips. *(Signing)* Gee, that was quick of me. Okay . . .

SARAH: Faster. Move it. Fly. Speed.

JAMES: I didn't understand that.

SARAH: *(In slow signed English)* If you do not sign faster, the hour will be over before you finish your opening speech.

JAMES: Oh, if! If. I. Do. Not. Sign. Fast. Er. The hour will be over before I finish my opening speech. *(It takes him a moment to comprehend "If" – she's doing it very slowly. As she goes on, her signing becomes faster, ending in a blur. James' voice trailing behind.)* Are you doing this because I'm not deaf? I used to pretend to be deaf, if that counts . . . . *(no response)* Well – good—okay. Why don't you come back and see me sometime and we'll have the same fun again.

SARAH: You give up easier than most.

JAMES: I give up easier than most?

SARAH: That's smart.

JAMES: Smart. Thank you

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TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *Time passes and then . . . Dinner in an Italian restaurant*

SARAH: Why are you trying to be different from the other hearing teachers?

JAMES: Why am I trying to be different from the other hearing teachers? Why did I have to bring you to an Italian restaurant to get you to talk to a hearing person?

SARAH: I don't need what you want to give me. I have a language that's just as good as yours!

JAMES: You don't need what I want to give you. Your language is just as good as mine – among the *deaf*, Sarah. Wouldn't you like to be able to function in the hearing world?

SARAH: No.

JAMES: No, I mean to be able to speak and lip read. *(she makes a grotesque face of a deaf person speaking – spitting, mouth contorted)* People who are born deaf look like that sometimes.

SARAH: Always.

JAMES: Always? Oh yes, I know: Very difficult to teach someone born deaf like you to speak and lip read, because you've never heard the sound of a human voice. But it can be done. *(Sarah looks away. James gets her attention)* I mean it. Al right, look you and I can start with lip reading, whudduya say? *(Sarah turns away)*

TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *Time again passes*

JAMES: I haven't seen you for days. You've been avoiding me. I even ate lunch in the cafeteria, thinking I'd see you.

SARAH: I've been eating in the kitchen so you wouldn't see me.

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JAMES: You've been eating in the kitchen so I wouldn't see you. Well, I didn't see you. You know, I hate to say this, but you're the most mysterious, attractive, angry person I've ever met. *(Sarah become conscious of another student who has moved in to feed the ducks too).*

SARAH: Go! Get out of here!

JAMES: *(Calling after the student)* Wait. Oh, that's all right, Lydia. Wait a . . . Come back . . . *(She's gone)* That was a bit rough, wasn't it?

SARAH: Should I treat her like she's handicapped?

JAMES: You think the only alternative to treating someone like they're handicapped is to treat them like that?

SARAH: Yes!

JAMES: You should give some seminars on interpersonal relationships.

SARAH: She's going to become dependent on you.

JAMES: Would that be so terrible if she became dependent on me?

SARAH: She'll fall in love with you.

JAMES: She's gonna fall in love with me. You know, all students don't automatically – Jesus Christ, that's quite a little leap you made there; from helping someone to learn something to dependency because of it, to falling in love as a result of the dependency. That's very nice, but it happens to be bullshit. You have a sign for b-u-l-l shit?

SARAH: Bullshit. *(a bull's horns with one hand; at the other end, a closed fist with the other hand; the closed fist springs open in James' face)* You're trying to con everyone.

JAMES: Excuse me, I'm trying to what everybody.

SARAH: C-o-n everybody.

JAMES: C-o-n. No, not everybody – only you. Wait a second, I'm going to invent a little sign here. Deaf-bullshit *(The same sign as above with one horn stuck in his ear).*

SARAH: I have to go.

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JAMES: You have to go? Fine, take your deaf-bullshit and go. *(Sarah leaves)* Oh, come on, Sarah! Sarah . . . . !

TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *The next day in a school hallway*

Sarah is pushing a maid's cleaning cart and doing her assigned jobs

JAMES: Hello. I'm sorry to interrupt your work.

SARAH: What do you want now?

JAMES: What do I want now? Okay, I want to know if you think you can't learn to speak, that you're not capable?

SARAH: Not speech talk again.

JAMES: Yeah, speech talk again. You're not retarded – you know that?

SARAH: Since I was twelve *(begins to sweep the floor)*

JAMES: Since you were twelve-right. But do you really believe it? Did not going home anymore after you were eighteen – did that have anything to do with your sister's friends? The boys you were going out with? *(She is silent)* Let me help you, damn it!

SARAH: You don't know what you're talking about!

JAMES: All right, you tell it to me right so I will know what I'm talking about!

SARAH: You're so . . .

JAMES: I'm so what? What am I? Nosy? Stupid? Misguided? Come on – whatever it is, I can take it. *(She lets him have it)*

SARAH and JAMES: *(Signing as James speaks the lines)* I have more than enough communication skills. You don't. They never did.

JAMES: They? Who's they?

SARAH AND JAMES: *(James translates now in the first person)* Hearing boys. They could never be bothered learning my language. No - that was too difficult. I was

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always expected to learn to speak. Well, I don't speak! I don't do things I can't do well. The boys who did try to communicate with me got about as far as: How are you, I am fine. *(Pause)* At first I let them have me because they would. Sex was something I could do as well as hearing girls. Better! It got to be that when I went home, the boys would be lined up on a waiting list my sister kept for me. Most of them didn't even take me for a Coke first. No introductions. No conversations. We just went straight to a dark place. But I liked that communication. I loved it. It made me feel a lot better than this bullshit talk you make. *(Finishes sweeping)*

SARAH: That's all you're going to find out.

JAMES: No. that's not all I'm going to find out.

SARAH: I live in a place you can't enter. It's out of reach. Deafness isn't the opposite of hearing, as you think. It's a silence full of sound.

JAMES: You live in a place I can't enter. Out of reach? Deafness isn't the opposite of hearing, as I think. It's a silence full of sound. Really? A silence full of sound?

SARAH: The sound of spring breaking up through the death of winter.

JAMES: The sound of . . . what does that mean? *(He doesn't understand the juxtaposition of winter, earth, broken, growth – which is how she beings the line; yet he is moved by it – Suddenly there is a softness, a closeness between them)*

SARAH: My secret. No hearing person has ever gotten in here to find out . . . No person, period.

JAMES: Your secret. No hearing person has ever gotten in there to find out . . . No person, period. *(Sarah runs from him)*

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TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *But Sarah does let James in to find out. In this next scene, James and Sarah have married*

ACTOR: *And after many struggles between the deaf and the hearing world, Sarah has decided to be a complainant in a legal action against the school where she and James met.*

ACTRESS: *Against James' wishes, she plans to present a speech in front of the state commission to demand that deaf teachers be hired at the school and to end the discrimination against the deaf population.*

JAMES: *(Sarah is practicing her speech in sign language while James addresses the audience)* Sarah Norman Leeds. My wife. Sarah Norman Leeds is deaf. She suffers a sensory-neutral deficit of unknown etiology. She has no residual hearing, derives no benefit from amplification. Sarah Norman Leeds' deafness is not correctable by surgery. It is incurable . . . but Sarah has decided that no is ever going to speak for her again. What I'm a bit confused about is how we got here. We met, we fought, we fell in love, we got married, I was happy, I thought [she] was happy. But now we're kicking each other's teeth in. (To Sarah) Explain it to me.

SARAH: You think it's my fault and that you're perfect.

JAMES: I think it's your fault and that I'm perfect. What a crock of . . . *(reigning in anger) (long pause)* When we go before the commission – do you want me to translate the speech exactly?

SARAH: Do you think you're going to translate for me?

JAMES: Yes. I'll tell you a little secret. They won't understand it if I don't translate it. . . . Look, if you're really going to go through with this, I'd like to share the experience with you.

SARAH: I can't say what I feel about being deaf through a hearing person.

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JAMES: You can't say what you feel about being deaf through . . . . through a hearing person.

SARAH: Does that make you angry?

JAMES: Angry . . . . and hurt. Let me see the speech, okay? Show me.

SARAH AND JAMES: *(Sarah steps forward and James back so we see Sarah, but hear James' voice)* For all my life I have been the creation of other people. The first thing I was ever able to understand was that everyone was supposed to hear but I couldn't and that was bad. Then they told me everyone was supposed to be smart but I was dumb. Then they said, oh no, I wasn't permanently dumb, only temporarily, but to be smart I had to become an imitation of the people who had from birth everything a person has to have to be good: ears that hear, mouth that speaks, eyes that read, brain that understands. Well, my brain understands a lot, and my eyes are my ears; and my hands are my voice; and my language, my speech, my ability to communicate is as great as yours. Greater, maybe, because I can communicate to you in one image an idea more complex than you can speak to each other in fifty words. For example, the sign "to connect," is a simple sign--but it means so much more when it is moved between us like this. Now it means to be joined in a shared relationship, to be individual yet as one. A whole concept just like that. Well, I want to be joined to other people, but for all my life people have spoken for me. She says; she means; she wants. As if there were no I. As if there were no one in here who could understand. *(When you say in here, motion to your chest or head).* Until you let me be an individual, an *I*, just as you are, you will never truly be able to come inside my silence and know me. And until you can do that, I will never let myself know you. Until that time, we cannot be joined. We cannot share a relationship. *(Silence---Long pause).*

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JAMES: *(re-enters scene with building anger)* Well, you . . . That's all very . . . That's moving – it is, but . . . .You . . . . yyou think they'e really . . . that we're really going to – we insensitive and inarticulate hearing people – that we're really going to be able to – that one out of a million is going to care enough to even try to come inside your silence, to bend to you . . . .

SARAH: Didn't you listen to anything I just said?

JAMES: Yes I did. I heard every word you just said and I'm going to tell you something you're not gonna like.

SARAH: Give it to me!

JAMES: I think your real bitch is that you are deaf and you wish you could hear. I don't think you think being deaf is so goddamn wonderful.

SARAH: Because of people like you.

JAMES: No! Not because of people like me. The administrators in ninety percent of the schools in the country would never hire you. You're dreaming a dream that can't come true. You're going nowhere, you're achieving nothing, you're changing nothing until you change.

SARAH: Until I speak!

JAMES: Until you speak – Okay, you wanna play that one – fine with me. Goddamn right! You want to be independent of me, you want people not to pity you, then you learn to read my lips and you learn to use that little mouth of yours for something besides eating. Come on! Read my lips! What am I saying? Say what I'm saying! What. Am. I. Saying? *(Sarah starts to sign something but he cuts her off. The rest of this speech is unsigned)* Shut up! You want to talk to me, then you learn my language! You will always be dependent on someone until you learn to speak. Now I want you to speak to me. Let me hear it. Speak! Speak! Speak!

SARAH: *(erupts like a volcano in speech - She doesn't sign)* Speech! Speech! Is that it? No! You want me to be your child. You want me to be like you. How do you like

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my voice? AM I beautiful? Am I what you want me to be? What about me? What I want? What I want? *(Silence. James reaches to touch her but she bolts away. Returns to signing softly but also speaks as she signs):*

The following ALS speech, translated into standard English would have SARAH speaking . . . "I have nothing; no hearing, no speech, no intelligence, no language. I have only you. I don't need you. I have me alone. Joined . . . unjoined"

SARAH: *(Signing)* Me have nothing. Me defy. Speech inept. Intelligence – tiny blockhead. English – blow away. Left one you Depend – no. Think myself enough. Join. Unjoined. *(Sarah exits)*

JAMES: *(silence . . . . drops head in defeat)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier

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